

The Platform Sutra: No-Thought and Formless Practice

1. Three negative terms

The Platform Sutra is famous for formulations translated as no-thought, no-form, and non-abiding. The prefix 'no-' should not be read as instructions to annihilate mental activity. The target is attachment or fixation. Thoughts may occur; the problem is being captured by them, objectifying them, or treating them as a permanent self. 'No-thought' is therefore better tested by how cognition functions than by whether cognition disappears.

2. No-thought is not blankness

Argument: (1) if awakening required the total absence of thought, it would be interrupted by every perception, judgment, or act of teaching; (2) awakened activity is portrayed as responsive and discriminating; therefore (3) the relevant freedom cannot be mere cognitive vacancy. The text's rhetoric attacks clinging to thought, including clinging to a purified state of no-thought.

3. Formless precepts

The work also presents 'formless precepts.' This does not mean ethics evaporates. The rhetoric relocates refuge, repentance, and vow within an awakened relation to mind. Historically, the striking point is that a text celebrated as immediate and iconoclastic places communal ritual speech at the center of its teaching. The binary 'meditation versus ritual' fails on the source itself.

4. Buddha-nature and nonduality

Claims that one's nature is originally awake can motivate very different conclusions. One reading: practice uncovers what is already present. Another: any search for a separate enlightened object reifies the very duality to be overcome. A dangerous third reading says conduct no longer matters because awakening is intrinsic. The text repeatedly blocks that inference by joining realization to disciplined non-attachment.

5. Question of language

If no formulation captures awakening, why formulate 'no-thought' at all? Zen language often functions performatively: a phrase is used to interrupt a mistaken conceptual grip, not to install a final metaphysical proposition. But 'performative' cannot become an excuse against interpretation. We can still ask what misconception a phrase opposes, what practices surround it, and what consequences follow from taking it one way rather than another.

6. Reading test

When a modern manual glosses no-thought as 'empty your mind,' ask for textual and practical consequences. Does that gloss explain the work's sermons, ethical vows, and active discrimination? If it predicts passivity where the source predicts responsive action, the gloss is too weak even if it sounds Zen-like.

1. A candidate account of no-thought

A tempting definition is: a person practices no-thought iff no thoughts occur. This cannot be right. The Platform Sutra does not recommend stupor, sensory shutdown, or an inability to respond. A better candidate is relational: thoughts may arise, but awareness does not become fixed on them as possessable objects or as a basis for grasping. On this reading, 'no' negates attachment to thought rather than the bare occurrence of mental events.

2. An argument against blankness

- 1 The text associates wisdom with responsive functioning rather than inert absence.
- 2 A condition in which cognition is simply suppressed would impair responsive functioning.
- 3 The text repeatedly pairs no-thought with non-abiding and non-attachment.
- 4 Non-abiding concerns the relation to mental contents, not their numerical absence.
- 5 Therefore interpreting no-thought as blank mental vacancy explains the terminology worse than interpreting it as non-fixation within ongoing cognition.

3. The formless-precepts problem

The text's 'formless' language can also mislead. Formless precepts do not show that communal forms, vows, repentance, or ritual are dispensable. The very teaching is transmitted through a structured ceremony and a text that prescribes verbal formulas. 'Formless' therefore has to be read as a transformation of what the form is taken to accomplish, not as evidence that form has disappeared. The ritual enacts a claim that refuge, repentance, and awakening are not external possessions while still giving them a public institutional shape.

4. The dilemma

Either no-thought means the literal absence of thinking or it does not. If it does, the doctrine conflicts with the text's model of active wisdom and ordinary functioning. If it does not, then the slogan cannot by itself tell us what relation to thought is intended. The second horn is preferable, but it creates interpretive work: non-attachment, non-abiding, and non-duality must be specified through the surrounding passages rather than imported from a modern meditation vocabulary.

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